

Giotto

The instigator of several Renaissance painting ideas, Giotto di Bondone (c.1266–1337) broke free from the static stylization of Byzantine art, introducing new ideals of naturalism and creating a convincing sense of pictorial space in his paintings. Mostly active in Florence, he also worked in Avignon, Padua and Naples. Giotto's main surviving fresco cycles are in the Arena Chapel in Padua, dating from c.1305. This series of 38 frescoes illustrates the lives of Christ and the Virgin, with varying emotions portrayed. In common with other artists of his day, he lacked technical knowledge of anatomy and perspective, but unlike any other medieval artist, he tried to make his figures look solid. Dramatic gestures emphasize emotion, while overlapping figures create impressions of space and depth. His *Lamentation of Christ*, c.1304–06, makes events credible by depicting the grief of biblical figures. In 1334, the city of Florence honoured Giotto with the title of *Magnus Magister* (Great Master), appointed him city architect and superintendent of public works, and invited him to design the new campanile of the cathedral.



Giotto, *Lamentation of Christ*, c.1304–6